

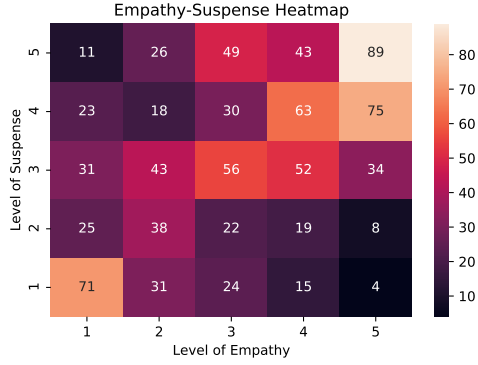


Figure 2: Human evaluation results for the investigation on reader’s empathy as visualized in a heatmap. The numbers in the heatmap indicate the counts of cases in which human participants feel the corresponding levels of empathy and suspense after reading a suspenseful story.

ing a story that explained the impending failure beforehand, and 36.3% of participants reported higher suspense when the impending failure was explained after the fact (21.6% tied). This indicates that it is slightly more effective in facilitating reader suspense perceptions by explaining how the protagonist will fail beforehand than after the fact. These results are not statistically significant.

Reader empathy: we recruited 30 participants to ask for both the level of empathy for the protagonist and the level of suspense they feel (level=1/2/3/4/5) after reading 30 randomly selected suspenseful stories generated by our method. Results are presented in Figure 2 as a heatmap which shows that a high level of perceived suspense is usually associated with a high level of reader’s empathy. However, there does exist a noticeable portion of participants who exhibit a very low level of perceived suspense even when they are reading suspenseful stories, associated with a very low level of empathy. One possible explanation for this phenomenon is methodological. Not a lot of character setup is given in the experiments and empathy may not be triggered strongly in some participants, who then also do not perceive suspense.

6 Conclusions

In this paper, we propose a theory-grounded *iterative-prompting-based planning* approach to generating suspenseful stories. To the best of our knowledge, this is the first attempt at suspenseful story generation with LLMs. Through extensive human evaluations, we prove that our method is more

capable of producing suspenseful stories than the baseline method. Our in-depth analysis of factors that affect suspense perception is also informative for story generation researchers and practitioners.

7 Limitations

Our system is developed for suspenseful story generation in English and our method has not been tested in other languages. The method is grounded in theory based on analysis of stories from a Western storytelling tradition. We believe that our method intuition is directly transferrable to other language scenarios, but to develop a fully functional non-English suspenseful story generation system, much additional effort must be required, especially for the necessary prompt engineering and human evaluations.

8 Ethical Considerations

This work uses human participants for evaluation. All procedures in this work have been approved by our institution’s Institutional Review Board (IRB). We provide the following statement on the first page of all our surveys, to make the human participants aware of the potential risk: “This survey may contain sensitive, distressing, or potentially triggering content. Please proceed only if you feel comfortable and are prepared to engage with thriller stories.”.

We ensure the human participants are fairly compensated by paying them at (and sometimes above) the hourly rate recommended by Prolific. We reasonably estimate the survey completion time to be two or three times (depending on the survey’s difficulty level we perceive) the time we have spent taking the survey.

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A List of Suspenseful Story Genres

- Psychological Thriller
- Crime Thriller
- Mystery Thriller
- Action Thriller
- Supernatural Thriller
- Survival Thriller
- Conspiracy Thriller
- Horror Thriller
- Political Thriller
- Survival Horror
- Techno Thriller
- Espionage Thriller
- Neo-Noir Thriller
- Erotic Thriller
- Disaster Thriller
- Serial Killer Thriller
- Home Invasion Thriller
- Legal Thriller
- Medical Thriller
- Historical Thriller
- Science Fiction Thriller
- War Thriller
- Spy Thriller
- Revenge Thriller
- Adventure Thriller
- Gothic Thriller
- Slasher Thriller
- Found Footage Thriller
- Post-Apocalyptic Thriller
- Wilderness Thriller
- Cyber Thriller
- Survivalist Thriller
- Mind-Bending Thriller
- Mind Game Thriller
- Vigilante Thriller
- Martial Arts Thriller
- Chase Thriller
- Identity Thriller
- Betrayal Thriller
- Dark Comedy Thriller
- Heist Thriller
- Political Conspiracy Thriller
- Stalker Thriller
- Paranormal Thriller
- Spy Action Thriller
- Neo-Western Thriller
- Psychological Horror Thriller
- Gothic Horror Thriller
- Found Footage Horror Thriller
- Survival Drama Thriller